

VERBAL ABILITY CHEAT SHEET

Complete Coverage | All Topics | Placements | CAT | UPSC

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1. SYNONYMS - WORDS WITH SIMILAR MEANINGS

What is it?

Words with same or nearly same meaning. Find the CLOSEST match in context.

Core Rules

- ✓ Same meaning in SAME context
- ✓ Consider connotation (emotional tone)
- ✓ Not just related word, but SYNONYM

Solving Steps

1. Understand exact meaning of given word
2. Note context if given
3. Eliminate opposite meanings
4. Compare remaining options
5. Choose best match

Common Synonym Pairs

Word	Synonym	Word	Synonym
Praise	Commend	Abundant	Plentiful
Intelligent	Clever	Beautiful	Attractive
Happy	Joyful	Angry	Furious
Big	Large	Small	Tiny
Begin	Start	End	Finish
Lazy	Sluggish	Quick	Swift
Honest	Truthful	Dishonest	Deceitful
Fortunate	Lucky	Unfortunate	Unlucky

Examples

EASY: DIMINISH
Answer: REDUCE (make smaller)

MEDIUM: NEBULOUS (unclear)
Answer: VAGUE (not clear)

HARD: OBFUSCATE
Answer: CONFUSE (make unclear)

2. ANTONYMS - WORDS WITH OPPOSITE MEANINGS

What is it?

Words with opposite meanings. Clearer than synonyms.

Core Rules

- ✓ Find **OPPOSITE** meaning
- ✓ **Not** just different, but **OPPOSITE**
- ✓ One clear opposite per word

Solving Steps

1. Identify meaning of word
2. Think opposite
3. Look for that opposite in options
4. Check prefix (un-, dis-, non-, anti-)

Common Antonym Pairs

Word	Antonym	Word	Antonym
Good	Bad	Happy	Sad
Big	Small	Hot	Cold
Begin	End	First	Last
Light	Dark	Up	Down
Rich	Poor	Success	Failure
Honest	Dishonest	Possible	Impossible
Clean	Dirty	Brave	Cowardly
Generous	Stingy	Lazy	Hardworking

Examples

EASY: ACCEPT
Answer: REJECT (opposite action)

MEDIUM: VERBOSE (talkative)
Answer: CONCISE (brief)

HARD: BENEVOLENT
Answer: MALICIOUS (kind vs cruel)

3. ONE WORD SUBSTITUTION - PHRASE TO SINGLE WORD

What is it?

Definition or phrase is given. Find ONE word meaning the same.

Common Types

Type	Example	Answer
Person who talks excessively	One who talks a lot	Garrulous
Fear words	Fear of heights	Acrophobia
Love words	One who loves books	Bibliophile
Government types	Rule by one person	Autocracy
Writing types	Story of own life	Autobiography
People descriptions	One who avoids society	Misanthrope
Quality words	Quality of being timely	Timeliness
Action words	Act of writing on walls	Graffiti

4. IDIOMS & PHRASES - NON-LITERAL MEANINGS

What is it?

Phrases where words together mean something different from literal meaning.

100+ Common Idioms

Idiom	Meaning	Idiom	Meaning
Break the ice	Start conversation	Burn bridges	End relationships
Hit the nail	Identify main issue	Spill the beans	Reveal secret
Piece of cake	Very easy	Under weather	Feeling ill
Cost arm & leg	Very expensive	Blue moon	Very rare
Beat around bush	Avoid main point	Call it a day	Stop working
Rain cats dogs	Heavy rain	Sleep on it	Think about later
Piece of mind	Express anger	Bring home bacon	Earn money
Let cat out	Reveal secret	Ball is rolling	Process started

Strategy

If unknown idiom, eliminate literal meanings. Look for opposite meaning if idiom is negative.

5. ROOT WORDS, PREFIX, SUFFIX

Common Root Words (Learn these!)

Root	Meaning	Examples
DICT	Say, Speak	Dictate, Predict, Diction
PORT	Carry	Transport, Import, Export
GRAPH/SCRIB	Write	Biography, Paragraph, Prescription
PHIL	Love	Philosophy, Philanthropist, Philharmonic
MORT	Death	Mortal, Immortal, Mortgage
BIO	Life	Biography, Biology, Antibiotic
CHRONO	Time	Chronological, Synchronize, Anachronism
GEO	Earth	Geography, Geology, Geometry
ASTRO	Star	Astronaut, Astronomy, Astrology
AQUA	Water	Aquarium, Aquatic, Aqueduct

Common Prefixes

Prefix	Meaning	Examples
UN-	Not	Unhappy, Unlock, Unclear
RE-	Again	Rebuild, Rewrite, Recall
DIS-	Not/Opposite	Disagree, Dislike, Disarm
PRE-	Before	Preview, Prejudge, Preheat
ANTI-	Against	Antisocial, Antidote, Antibacterial
SUB-	Below/Under	Submarine, Subway, Subtract
OVER-	Above/Too much	Overcome, Overflow, Overact
INTER-	Between	Interactive, International, Interchange

Common Suffixes

Suffix	Meaning	Examples
-TION	Action/Result	Creation, Application, Education
-LY	In manner of	Quickly, Happily, Slowly
-ABLE	Capable of	Readable, Movable, Comfortable
-NESS	Quality	Happiness, Darkness, Kindness
-MENT	Result	Development, Agreement, Improvement
-OUS	Full of	Dangerous, Generous, Ambitious
-LESS	Without	Hopeless, Fearless, Homeless
-ISH	Having quality	Foolish, Selfish, Childish

6. PARTS OF SPEECH - QUICK REFERENCE

Part	Function	Examples
NOUN	Names person, place, thing	Cat, Happiness, India
VERB	Action or state	Run, Is, Think
ADJECTIVE	Describes noun	Beautiful, Blue, Happy
ADVERB	Describes verb/adjective	Quickly, Very, Well
PRONOUN	Replaces noun	He, She, It, They
PREPOSITION	Shows relationship	In, On, At, To
CONJUNCTION	Joins words/clauses	And, But, Or, Because
ARTICLE	Specifies noun	A, An, The

7. TENSES - COMPLETE GUIDE

Present Tenses

Tense	Form	Example
Present Simple	V1	She reads daily
Present Continuous	is/are + V-ing	She is reading now
Present Perfect	has/have + V3	She has read it
Present Perf Cont	has/have been + V-ing	She has been reading

Past Tenses

Tense	Form	Example
Past Simple	V2	She read yesterday
Past Continuous	was/were + V-ing	She was reading
Past Perfect	had + V3	She had read before I arrived
Past Perf Cont	had been + V-ing	She had been reading for 2 hours

Future Tenses

Tense	Form	Example
Future Simple	will + V1	She will read tomorrow
Future Continuous	will be + V-ing	She will be reading at 5pm
Future Perfect	will have + V3	She will have read by 5pm
Future Perf Cont	will have been + V-ing	She will have been reading for 2 hours

Key Rules

- ✓ Simple = regular/habitual
- ✓ Continuous = happening at specific time
- ✓ Perfect = completed with relevance to another time

8. SUBJECT-VERB AGREEMENT

Golden Rule

SINGULAR SUBJECT → SINGULAR VERB
PLURAL SUBJECT → PLURAL VERB

Tricky Cases

Case	Rule	Example
Collective Noun	Usually singular	The team IS winning
Either...or	Agrees with nearer	Either he OR they ARE
Everyone/Nobody	Singular	Everyone HAS done
Both...and	Plural	Both he and she ARE
Neither...nor	Agrees with nearer	Neither he nor they ARE
All/Some/None	Check context	All ARE (plural items)
Fractions	Plural if of plural	Half the boys ARE here
Percentages	Plural if plural	80% ARE passing

Common Mistakes

- X "The team are winning" (team = singular)
- X "Neither he nor she are right" (should be "is")
- X "Everyone have done" (should be "has")
- X "The list of items are long" (list = singular)

9. ARTICLES: A, AN, THE

Rules

A = consonant sound (a book, a university)
AN = vowel sound (an apple, an hour)
THE = specific/known thing

When to Use THE

- ✓ Specific thing: "I saw a cat. The cat was black"
- ✓ Only one: "the Sun", "the President"
- ✓ Superlatives: "the best", "the oldest"
- ✓ Rivers/mountains: "the Amazon", "the Alps"

When NOT to Use THE

- ✓ General plural: "Dogs are loyal"
- ✓ Proper nouns: "John", "Paris"
- ✓ Abstract nouns: "love", "happiness"
- ✓ Languages: "English is easy"

10. PREPOSITIONS - LOCATION & COMMON ERRORS

Location Prepositions

Preposition	Use	Example
IN	Inside space	In the room, in India
ON	On surface	On the table, on the wall
AT	Specific point	At home, at the station
BETWEEN	Two things	Between you and me
AMONG	Three+ things	Among the group
ABOVE	Higher	Above the clouds
BELOW	Lower	Below sea level
UNDER	Beneath	Under the bridge

Critical Verb + Preposition (Most Tested!)

Correct	Incorrect	Correct	Incorrect
Agree WITH	Agree TO	Consist OF	Comprise OF
Different FROM	Different TO	Blame FOR	Blame TO
Compare WITH	Compare TO	Reason WITH	Reason TO
Depend ON	Depend FROM	Insist ON	Insist FOR
Succeed IN	Succeed AT	Interfere IN	Interfere TO
Comply WITH	Comply TO	Assent TO	Assent WITH
Access TO	Access OF	Adequate FOR	Adequate TO
Adapt TO	Adapt WITH	Adhere TO	Adhere WITH

11. ACTIVE AND PASSIVE VOICE

Quick Difference

Voice	Focus	Example
ACTIVE	Subject does action	She ate the apple
PASSIVE	Action done to subject	The apple was eaten by her

Conversion Rule

1. Move object to subject
2. Add be + V3
3. Original subject becomes "by" phrase

Passive Voice Tenses

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple Present	She writes	It is written
Present Continuous	She is writing	It is being written
Simple Past	She wrote	It was written
Past Continuous	She was writing	It was being written
Present Perfect	She has written	It has been written
Past Perfect	She had written	It had been written
Future Simple	She will write	It will be written
Future Perfect	She will have written	It will have been written

12. ERROR DETECTION - COMMON MISTAKES

Error Types

Error Type	Example	Correction
Subject-Verb	He don't like	He doesn't like
Tense Consistency	I go and saw	I go and see / I went and saw
Pronoun Reference	When John met Peter, he was happy	Clarify who "he" is
Misplaced Modifier	Running, the tree fell	As he was running, the tree fell
Parallelism	I like reading, writing and to play	I like reading, writing, playing
Wrong Preposition	Different than	Different from
Articles	He is teacher	He is a teacher
Comma Splice	I am here, you are there	I am here; you are there

What to Check

- ✓ Subject & Verb → Do they match?
- ✓ Pronouns → Clear reference?
- ✓ Tenses → Consistent?
- ✓ Prepositions → Correct?
- ✓ Articles → A, An, The?
- ✓ Comparisons → Correct form?

13. READING COMPREHENSION STRATEGY

4-Step Approach

- STEP 1: Read passage (understand, don't memorize)
- STEP 2: Scan question (know what to find)
- STEP 3: Find relevant part (use keywords)
- STEP 4: Eliminate & choose (compare options)

Question Types

Type	Strategy
Main Idea	Usually in first/last paragraph
Inference	Use evidence from passage, don't go too far
Fact/Detail	Look directly in passage
Tone	Check adjectives, punctuation
Vocabulary in Context	Read before and after the word
Author's Purpose	Why did author write this?

Wrong Answer Patterns

- X Too specific (only part)
- X Too broad (general)
- X Contradicts passage
- X Not mentioned
- X Opposite of passage

14. PARA JUMBLES - SENTENCE REARRANGEMENT

4-Step System

STEP 1: Find OPENING sentence

- Introduces topic
- Doesn't refer to previous
- Has definite article or name

STEP 2: Find CLOSING sentence

- Concludes/summarizes
- Final thought

STEP 3: Link sentences

- Use connector words (However, Moreover)
- Use pronouns (This, That, These)
- Follow logical flow

STEP 4: Verify flow

- Read complete sequence
- Does it make sense?

Connector Words

Type	Words
Addition	Moreover, Furthermore, Additionally, Also
Contrast	However, But, Nevertheless, Yet
Cause-Effect	Therefore, Thus, So, As a result, Because
Sequence	First, Then, Next, Finally, After
Example	For example, For instance, Such as
Conclusion	In conclusion, Finally, Ultimately, Thus

15. FILL IN THE BLANKS - CONTEXT CLUES

Solving Steps

1. Read sentence for meaning
2. Identify word type (noun, verb, adj, adv)
3. Check tone (positive/negative)
4. Look for context clues (synonym, antonym, definition)
5. Eliminate obviously wrong
6. Test answer in sentence

Context Clue Types

Type	Signal Words	Example
Synonym	Similar, Like, Same as	Smart or _____ (Intelligent)
Antonym	Unlike, However, But, Opposite	Unlike his brother's rash approach, she was _____
Definition	Which is to say, That is, In other words	Benevolent, which is to say _____, helped everyone
Inference	Because, Since, So, Therefore	He was late, so he was _____

16. CLOZE TEST - FILL BLANKS IN PASSAGE

Approach

1. Read FULL passage first
2. Understand passage theme
3. Look at blanks in context
4. Both grammar AND vocabulary tested
5. Verify answer maintains flow

What to Check

- ✓ Noun/Verb agreement
- ✓ Tense consistency
- ✓ Meaning in context
- ✓ Preposition accuracy
- ✓ Overall passage flow

17. CRITICAL REASONING - ANALYZING ARGUMENTS

Question Types

Type	What to Do
Strengthen Argument	Find evidence supporting main claim
Weaken Argument	Find evidence contradicting claim
Assumption	What unstated belief is needed?
Conclusion	What must logically follow?
Identify Flaw	What's wrong with reasoning?
Parallel Logic	Find similar argument structure

Common Logical Flaws

Flaw Type	What It Is
Overgeneralization	All based on few examples
False Cause	Correlation treated as causation
Appeal to Authority	Famous person said it, so true
Ad Hominem	Attack person, not argument
Circular Reasoning	Conclusion used in premise
Either/Or Fallacy	Only two options when more exist

18. SENTENCE IMPROVEMENT - MAKING SENTENCES BETTER

What to Check

- ✓ Remove redundancy (unnecessary words)
- ✓ Improve clarity (clearer expression)
- ✓ Fix grammar errors
- ✓ Better word choice (stronger verbs)
- ✓ Correct construction (parallel, modifier)

Common Improvements

Poor	Better
He is a man who is intelligent	He is intelligent
In my opinion, I think that...	I think that...
She walked slowly and carefully	She walked carefully
The reason is because...	The reason is that...
Past history	History (history is always past)
Both are equal alike	Both are equal
He is a person that likes...	He is a person who likes...

19. FINAL TIPS BY EXAM

PLACEMENTS (TCS, Infosys, Wipro)

- Focus: Vocabulary, Basic Grammar, Simple RC
- Speed: 30-40 sec/question
- Key: Master 500 common words + basic grammar

CAT (MBA)

- Focus: Complex passages, Advanced vocabulary
- Speed: 2-3 min/question
- Key: Negative marking, balance speed & accuracy

UPSC (Civil Services)

- Focus: Comprehension, Grammar, Clear expression
- Speed: 2-3 min/question
- Key: No negative marking, accuracy important

30-DAY SUCCESS PLAN

Days	Focus
1-5	Vocabulary (synonyms, antonyms, 100+ idioms)
6-10	Grammar (tenses, agreement, voice)
11-15	Application (para jumbles, fill blanks, errors)

16-20	Reading (10+ passages, different questions)
21-25	Full practice tests (3-4 tests)
26-30	Weak area revision & final polish